

Module 5: PARTS OF SPEECH I.

The grammatical rank scale is a hierarchical ordering of linguistic units, from the smallest to the largest. It consists of the morpheme, word, phrase, clause, and sentence, in which a unit of a higher rank is typically composed of units of the next lower rank. This scale helps to analyze language structure and understand how smaller units combine to form larger ones.

The following are examples of components of grammatical rankscale:

- **Morpheme:** The smallest unit of meaning. It can be a free morpheme (such as, "boy") or a bound morpheme (such as the "-s" in "boys").
- **Word:** A combination of one or more morphemes (e.g., "boys").
- **Phrase:** A group of words that function together as a grammatical unit (e.g., "the boys").
- **Clause:** A group of phrases that contains a subject and a verb (e.g., "the boys played").
- **Sentence:** A complete thought that consists of one or more clauses.

How the rank scale works

The rank scale is a hierarchy where each rank is built from the one below it.

- **Morphemes:** combine to form words.
- **Words:** combine to form phrases.
- **Phrases:** combine to form clauses.
- **Clauses:** combine to form sentences.

Some aspects of Word formation

Word formation in English is the process of creating new words from existing ones through methods such as affixation (adding prefixes or suffixes), compounding (combining words), conversion (changing a word's class, e.g., a noun to a verb) blending (e.g., "smog"), clipping (e.g., "phone" from

"telephone"), acronymy (NATO), alphabetism (e.g., USA), borrowing (e.g., “beret” from French to English) etc.

Other word formation processes can easily be recognised and used by any user of language except affixation which is a bit tricky and complex. So, we will look at the processes of using prefixes and suffixes, namely, affixes to form new words from existing ones.

Affixation

To know how affixes are used in forming new words, we must learn about the different types of morpheme. Morphemes are of two types: free morpheme and bound morpheme.

The free morpheme is that which can stand alone to form a word. Examples include “boy”, “girl”, “school”, etc. These are also whole words that cannot be broken further down.

A bound morpheme is that which cannot stand alone but will have to be attached to a free morpheme to express a full meaning. Examples are the “-s” in “boys”, the “-ren” in “children”, the “ous” in “joyous”.

The bound morpheme is divided into two categories: Inflectional morpheme and Derivational morpheme.

- **Inflectional morphemes:** Inflectional affixes are usually suffixes and do not change the meaning or grammatical class of the word to which they are added. Rather, they serve to indicate tense or number in verbs, number, or possession in nouns and degree in adjective and adverbs.
- - **Verb:** compute, computes, computed, computing
 - **Noun:** book, books, book's
 - **Pronoun:** they, them, theirs
 - **Adjective:** soft softer softest

Derivational morphemes are of two types: Derivational affixes usually affect the grammatical class of the words they are attached to or change their meanings. They can be prefixes and suffixes. A **prefix is added to the beginning** of a word (or root word). A suffix is a morpheme added to the end of a word to change its meaning or part of speech.

For example, adding "-ness" to "happy" which is a adjective creates "happiness," a noun, while adding "-ly" to "quick" creates "quickly," an adverb.

The most common prefixes used to form new nouns in academic English are: co- and sub- , and the most common suffixes are: -tion, -ity, -er, -ness, -ism, -ment, -ant, -ship, -age, -ery.

Word classes/Parts of speech

There are eight word classes in English. In this module, we will look at the four major ones such as Nouns, Pronouns, Verbs and Adjectives.

Nouns

Nouns in English are words that name a person, place, thing, or idea. Nouns function as the subject, object, or complement in a sentence.

Types of Nouns

These are the types of Nouns we have in the English language:

Common noun: refers to something general or common, e.g. “boy”, “child”, “table”, “window”.

Proper noun: refers to a specific person, location, thing, e.g., “Ademola”, “Donald Trump”, “Atlantic Ocean”, “River Niger”. These nouns have their first letter capitalised no matter where they occur in a sentence.

Abstract noun: this refers to something Intangible which cannot be touched or seen, e.g. “happiness”, “beauty”, etc.

Collective noun: this type of noun refers to groups of people, animals or things as a single unit. Examples include “herd”, “crew”, “audience”, “flock”, etc.

Count and non-count Nouns:

A count noun is a noun that can be counted and has both a singular and a plural form. It can be used with numbers and words such as "a," "an," "many," "few," "several," or "each".

Examples: a car, few books, an idea, and two hands.

Non-count nouns do not have plural forms, are used with singular verbs, and cannot be preceded by "a" or "an". Examples include concepts such as "information" or "advice" and substances such as "water" or "sugar", "Oil", "petrol", "beans", etc.

An information ✗ some information ✓

An advice ✗ some advice ✓

A petrol ✗ lots of petrol/some petrol ✓

Compound Noun: a noun made up of two or more existing words, e.g. "copycat", "chessboard". They can be written together, e.g., "blackbird", separately, e.g., "Atlantic Ocean", with hyphen, e.g. "brother-in-law."

Pluralising Nouns.

The plural of English nouns is generally formed by adding **-s** to the singular noun. Other rules apply to nouns ending in specific letters, such as adding **-es** to words ending in -s, -sh, -ch, -x, and -z. For nouns ending in a consonant and -y, the -y is changed to **-ies** (e.g., baby to babies. Nouns pluralised this way are called **Regular nouns**.

Regular plurals

- **Add -s:** This is the most common rule.
 - *Example:* cat → cats, book → books, house → houses

- **Add -es:** Use this for nouns ending in -s, -sh, -ch, -x, or -z.
 - *Example:* bus → buses, box → boxes, church → churches, quiz → quizzes
- **Change -y to -ies:** When a consonant comes before -y.
 - *Example:* baby → babies, story → stories
- **Keep -y and add -s:** When a vowel comes before -y.
 - *Example:* toy → toys, monkey → monkeys
- **Change -f or -fe to -ves:** In many cases.
 - *Example:* knife → knives, wife → wives
 - In other cases, add only -s, e.g., chief is chiefs not *chieves.

Irregular plurals

These words do not follow the standard rules: man → men, child → children, foot → feet, mouse → mice, sheep → sheep, deer → deer

Foreign words/plurals

These are loan words into the English language that do not follow the rules of the English pluralisation process. Examples are formula-formulae, plateau-plateaux, forum- fora, datum- data.

Some Concord rules on nouns

Possessive Nouns and Plural Nouns.

Note that to show possession in English, nouns take apostrophe and -s, e.g., “Ade's bag.” This is quite different from plural nouns that take -s and other variations of -s. For irregular nouns, an apostrophe and -s are added to show possession, e.g., “the man's cat”, “the men's cats.” For regular nouns that already have -s, only the apostrophe is added in the case of plural forms, e.g., “the girls’

bag” – “the girls’ bags.” For singular nouns already ending in -s, e.g., “boss”, we have the “boss's table” and for its plural form, we have the “bosses’ table.”

To be in subject-verb agreement, plural nouns acting as subjects of sentences or clauses need plural verbs, as in this example: “The Fabelmans often visit national parks together.”

It is also important to remember that when a noun is plural, any pronoun referring to it should also be plural: “The Fabelmans often spend their vacation time together.”

Most nouns can be turned into plural nouns, including collective nouns, which represent groups:

- one team
- two teams

Non-count/Mass Nouns

These nouns are generally not pluralised in the English language, but there are a few cases they are. Here are a couple of examples of nouns that are uncountable in some contexts and countable in others.

- Chicken is a good source of protein.
- Countable: We saw several chickens running around the barnyard.
- Mass: She studied art as an undergraduate.
- Countable: Theater is one of the performing arts.

There are nouns whose plural forms match their singular ones as well:

- counsel (as in lawyer) – counsel
- craft (as in vessel, like a boat or plane) – craft
- series – series
- species – species

You need to see these nouns in context to identify them as singular or plural. Consider the following sentence: “Bola caught one fish, and I caught three fish.”

However, some words of this kind, including “*fish*”, do have contexts in which the more standard plural is used. “Fishes”, for example, is often used to refer to multiple species of fish, especially in scientific contexts. The same goes for water- “Waters” for water bodies, “salt-salts” for different kinds of salt.

Plurals of compound nouns

Compound nouns—whether they are open, hyphenated, or closed up—it is typically the main part of the compound (the part that is modified by the rest of the compound) that changes form to make the whole compound plural:

- *mother-in-law* – *mothers-in-law*
- *return on investment* – *returns on investment*
- *passerby* – *passersby*

Even when a compound noun is made up of two nouns, there is a modifying noun (called an attributive noun) and a main noun. The modifying noun nearly always comes first, and the main noun, usually the second one, changes form:

- toothbrush – toothbrushes
- wage earner – wage earners
- apartment building – apartment buildings

You should also note that to use “a pair” with nouns, use the phrase “a pair of” followed by a plural noun that represents two items used together, like “a pair of shoes” or “a pair of scissors”. When the entire phrase “a pair of [plural noun]” is the subject of the sentence, use a singular verb because the subject is the singular “pair” (e.g., “This pair of shoes **is** on sale”).

“A pair of trousers” is the correct phrase because “trousers” is a plural-only noun referring to an item with two connected parts, as in “pants,” “scissors,” or “glasses”. While the singular form “trouser” can be used as an adjective (e.g., “trouser leg”), it is incorrect to refer to the garment itself as “a trouser”. **“A pair of trousers” is correct:** Because the garment consists of two legs, it is treated as a pair, similar to “a pair of scissors” or “a pair of glasses”. **“A trouser” is**

incorrect: The singular form is not used to refer to the garment itself, as it is a plural-only noun. **Adjective use is correct:** The word "trouser" can function as an adjective, as in a trouser leg.

Pronouns

A **pronoun** is a word that is used in place of a noun or noun phrase to avoid repetition and make sentences more concise. Pronouns refer to people, places, things, concepts, or ideas that have already been mentioned or are understood from the context.

Types

Pronoun Type	Function	Examples
Personal	Refers to a specific person, place, or thing; changes form based on person (1st, 2nd, 3rd), number, gender, and case.	<i>I, me, you, he, him, she, her, it, we, us, they, them</i>
Possessive	Indicates ownership or possession.	<i>mine, yours, his, hers, ours, theirs</i>
Reflexive	Used as an object when the subject and object of a verb are the same; ends in "-self" or "-selves".	<i>myself, yourself, himself, herself, itself, ourselves, themselves</i>

Intensive	Emphasises a preceding noun or pronoun (identical forms to reflexive pronouns).	<i>herself, himself, myself</i> (e.g., "The boss <i>himself</i> called me")
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Demonstrative	Points to specific nouns, indicating distance (in time or space).	<i>this, that, these, those</i>
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Interrogative	Introduces a question.	<i>who, whom, whose, what, which</i>
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Relative	Introduces a relative clause, providing additional information about an antecedent noun.	<i>who, whom, whose, which, that</i>
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Indefinite	Refers to a non-specific person or thing.	<i>anyone, somebody, nothing, all, many, either</i>
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Reciprocal	Expresses a mutual relationship or action	<i>each other, one another</i>
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between two or more
subjects.

Pronouns in sentences

1. My family loves popcorn. **We** make them every Friday for movie night.
2. The woman **who** called earlier didn't leave a message.
3. She looked at the envelope and said, "**This** has no return address, we'd *better add one.*"
4. **Everybody** *was late to work because of the traffic jam.*
5. She checked **herself** *out of the hotel thirty minutes before checkout time.*
6. I built this house **myself**.
7. She had forgotten her jacket, so I gave her **mine**.
8. **Which** movie do you want to watch?
9. Javier and Priya, the two top salespeople on our team, are competing with **each other** *to be named salesperson of the year.*

Verbs

A **verb** is a word that describes an action (physical or mental), an occurrence, or a state of being. Verbs are a crucial component of language, as every complete sentence must contain at least one. Verbs provide information about what the subject of a sentence is doing or experiencing. They can take various forms to express different grammatical meanings, such as tense (past, present, future), person, number, voice, and mood.

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TYPES OF VERBS

Finite Verbs

A finite verb is a verb that has a subject and shows tense, person, or number. It can stand alone as the main verb in a complete sentence or independent clause.

e.g: cook, play, slept

- Example: We cooked rice yesterday
- She eats pasta everyday

Non-finite verbs

They are verb forms that do not show tense, person, or number, and cannot be the main verb of an independent clause.

Types of non-finite verbs

- **Gerunds**: These are verbs ending in "-ing" that function as nouns.
 - **Example: "Swimming** is fun" (the gerund "swimming" is the subject of the sentence).
- **Participles**: These have two forms: present participles (-ing) and past participles (-ed or other past forms). They act as adjectives or are part of verb phrases.
 - **Present Participle Example**: "The **running** water" (the participle "running" describes "water").
 - **Past Participle Example**: "The **baked** bread" (the participle "baked" describes "bread").
- **Infinitives**: These are the base form of a verb, usually preceded by "to". They can function as nouns, adjectives, or adverbs.

- **Example:** "She likes **to play** soccer" (the infinitive "to play" is the object of "likes").

Auxiliary (helping) verbs

Auxiliary verbs are also called “helping verbs.” They are used in English to change another verb’s tense, voice, or mood. When auxiliary verbs are used, there is always a main verb that represents the main action. However, the auxiliary verb must still be conjugated correctly.

The main auxiliary verbs are also called primary auxiliary verbs. They are “*be*”, “*have*”, and “*do*”. We explain how they’re used specifically below, but here are a few quick examples:

I **have** eaten rice many times today.

That piece of meat **was** eaten by me.

Did you eat my spaghetti?

The auxiliary forms of BE, HAVE and DO

BE: am, is, was, are, were, be, been, being.

HAVE: have, has, had, having

DO: does, do, did,

Modal or Secondary auxiliary verbs

A modal auxiliary verb is a helping verb that expresses necessity, possibility, permission, or ability. Common modal verbs include "can," "could," "may," "might," "must," "shall," "should," "will," and "would". They are used with a main verb's infinitive form (e.g., "can go," "should ask") and do not change for subject-verb agreement.

Examples

- **Ability:** "She **can** swim."
- **Permission:** "You **may** leave now."
- **Possibility:** "It **might** rain."
- **Obligation:** "You **must** finish your homework."
- **Suggestion:** "You **should** try the new restaurant."
- **Past habit:** "I **would** often walk to school."

Note that primary auxiliary verbs can function as main verbs in sentences. In this case, they are called main verbs. The verbs BE, DO and HAVE can stand as main verbs in these forms:

BE: is, am, are, were, was, as seen in these sentences:

I am in school

She is my friend

We are in the house

I was with the Dean yesterday

We were there together.

HAVE

The verb "**have**" can function as a **main verb** in several contexts, primarily to express **possession, experience, or actions/activities**. When used as a main verb, it acts like any other regular verb and requires the auxiliary verb "**do**" (or "did"/"does") to form questions and negative sentences in the simple present and simple past tenses.

Uses and Examples of "Have" as a Main Verb

1. Possession or Ownership

This is the most common meaning of "have" as a main verb, indicating that something belongs to someone.

- **Affirmative:** I have a car, she has a dog
- **Negative:** They **don't** have a dog, she doesn't have a bag.
- **Question:** **Do** you have a pen? Does she have a car?

DO

When used as a main verb, "do" usually means to

perform, carry out, complete, or deal with an action or task. It can be used in various tenses and forms (do, does, did, doing, done), just as other main verbs.

Here are examples of "do" as a main verb:

In the Present Tense

- **I do** my homework every evening.
- She **does** the dishes every night.
- We **do** a lot of work around the town.
- What **does** he **do** for a living? (The first "does" is auxiliary, the second "do" is the main verb asking about his job)
- They say they don't care, but they **do**. (Here "do" is a substitute for "care" to avoid repetition)

In the Past Tense

- He **did** something special yesterday.

- I **did** some shopping this morning.
- We **did** 80 miles on the first day of our cycling holiday.
- She **did** her hair and then she was ready.
- He **did** as I said.

In Other Forms

- What are you **doing** today, anything interesting?
- I am **doing** the best I can.
- Have you **done** your essay yet?
- The work will be **done** on behalf of the company.
- Can you **do** me a favor?

In these examples, "do" (or its form) is the principal verb of the sentence, expressing the core action or idea.

Also note that in a sentence with primary auxiliary and modal auxiliary verbs, the modal auxiliary verbs come first in the sequence, e.g., "we might have left the bag in his car." "He should have done as he was told."

NUMBER IN VERBS

Number in verbs refers to the grammatical principle that a verb's form changes to indicate whether its subject is singular (one) or plural (more than one). This is known as **subject-verb agreement**.

Subject-Verb Agreement

The basic rule in English is that a singular subject takes a singular verb form, and a plural subject takes a plural verb form.

Subject Type

Subject Example

Verb Example

Singular (Third Person)	He, She, It, The dog	runs, walks, eats
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Plural (All Persons)	We, You, They, dogs	run, walk, eat
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Singular (First/Second Person)	I, You	run, walk, eat
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The verb "to be" is an exception, as it changes form based on both person and number (*I am, you are, he/she/it is, we/they are*).

Voice in Verbs

Verb voice indicates whether the subject performs the action (active voice) or receives it (passive voice). Active voice is direct and concise, with the subject as the doer (e.g., "The dog chased the ball"). Passive voice is often less direct, with the subject being acted upon (e.g., "The ball was chased by the dog"). The passive voice is formed by using a form of the verb "to be" and the past participle of the main verb.

Active voice

- **Definition:** The subject of the sentence performs the action.
- **Example:** "The cat chased the bird".
- **Characteristics:** Generally preferred for being more direct, dynamic, and forceful.

Passive voice

- **Definition:** The subject of the sentence receives the action.
- **Example:** "The bird was chased by the cat".

- **Formation:** Created by using a form of "to be" plus the past participle of the verb (e.g., "is eaten," "was moved").
- **Characteristics:** Can be useful when the performer of the action is unknown or unimportant, or to emphasise the action itself.

ADJECTIVES

Adjectives are words that describe or modify nouns or pronouns, providing more information about their qualities or characteristics. They tell you "what kind," "which one," or "how much" about a noun, such as in the phrases "the **tall** building" or "**three** white flowers".

- **Function:** Adjectives add detail and specificity to a sentence.
- **Examples:**
 - **Positive:** A word in its basic form, like "**big**" or "**happy**". E.g The house is big.
 - **Comparative:** Used to compare two nouns, like "**bigger**" or "**happier**". E.g That house is bigger than this one.
 - **Superlative:** Used to compare more than two nouns, indicating the highest degree, like "**biggest**" or "**happiest**".

E.g This house is the biggest of all

Adjectives can be placed before the noun they modify (e.g., "the **proud** soldier"). They can also be placed after a linking verb, like "is," "are," or "was" (e.g., "the soldier is **proud**").